

Diabetes Management Guide

What is Diabetes?

Diabetes is a chronic medical condition that affects how your body processes blood sugar (glucose). Glucose is vital for health as it's an important source of energy for cells. In diabetes, the body either doesn't produce enough insulin or can't effectively use the insulin it produces.

Types of Diabetes

Type 1 Diabetes

- **Cause:** Autoimmune condition where the body attacks insulin-producing cells
- **Onset:** Usually diagnosed in children and young adults
- **Treatment:** Requires daily insulin injections or pump therapy
- **Prevalence:** Accounts for 5-10% of all diabetes cases

Type 2 Diabetes

- **Cause:** Body becomes resistant to insulin or doesn't produce enough
- **Onset:** Usually develops in adults over 45, but increasingly seen in younger people
- **Treatment:** Lifestyle changes, oral medications, and sometimes insulin
- **Prevalence:** Accounts for 90-95% of all diabetes cases

Gestational Diabetes

- **Cause:** Develops during pregnancy
- **Risk:** Increases risk of Type 2 diabetes later in life
- **Treatment:** Diet, exercise, and sometimes insulin
- **Resolution:** Usually resolves after delivery

Symptoms and Warning Signs

Common Symptoms

- Increased thirst and frequent urination
- Extreme hunger
- Unexplained weight loss
- Fatigue and weakness
- Blurred vision

- Slow-healing sores or frequent infections
- Tingling or numbness in hands or feet

Emergency Symptoms (Seek Immediate Care)

- Blood sugar above 300 mg/dL
- Confusion or loss of consciousness
- Rapid breathing
- Fruity-smelling breath
- Severe abdominal pain

Blood Sugar Target Ranges

For Most Adults with Diabetes

- **Before meals:** 80-130 mg/dL
- **2 hours after meals:** Less than 180 mg/dL
- **A1C level:** Below 7%

Note: Target ranges may vary based on individual circumstances. Consult your healthcare provider.

Daily Management Strategies

1. Blood Glucose Monitoring

- Check blood sugar as recommended by your doctor
- Keep a log of readings
- Identify patterns and triggers
- Use continuous glucose monitors (CGM) if prescribed

2. Medication Management

- Take medications exactly as prescribed
- Never skip doses
- Understand how each medication works
- Report side effects to your doctor

3. Healthy Eating

Recommended Foods:

- Non-starchy vegetables (broccoli, spinach, peppers)
- Whole grains (brown rice, quinoa, oats)

- Lean proteins (chicken, fish, tofu)
- Healthy fats (avocado, nuts, olive oil)
- Fresh fruits in moderation

Foods to Limit:

- Sugary drinks and desserts
- Refined carbohydrates (white bread, pasta)
- Processed foods high in sodium
- Saturated and trans fats

4. Physical Activity

- Aim for 150 minutes of moderate exercise per week
- Include both aerobic and strength training
- Check blood sugar before and after exercise
- Stay hydrated during physical activity

5. Stress Management

- Practice relaxation techniques (meditation, yoga)
- Get adequate sleep (7-9 hours per night)
- Maintain social connections
- Seek counseling if needed

Preventing Complications

Regular Health Screenings

- **Eye exams:** Annually to check for retinopathy
- **Foot exams:** Daily self-checks, professional exam annually
- **Kidney function:** Blood and urine tests annually
- **Dental checkups:** Every 6 months
- **Blood pressure:** At every doctor visit
- **Cholesterol levels:** At least annually

Foot Care

- Inspect feet daily for cuts, blisters, or sores
- Wash feet daily with warm water
- Keep skin moisturized
- Trim toenails carefully
- Wear comfortable, well-fitting shoes
- Never walk barefoot

Sick Day Management

- Continue taking diabetes medications
- Check blood sugar more frequently
- Stay hydrated
- Monitor for ketones if blood sugar is high
- Contact doctor if unable to eat or keep food down

Hypoglycemia (Low Blood Sugar)

Symptoms

- Shakiness or trembling
- Sweating
- Rapid heartbeat
- Dizziness or lightheadedness
- Hunger
- Confusion or irritability

Treatment (Rule of 15)

1. Check blood sugar
2. If below 70 mg/dL, consume 15g of fast-acting carbs:
 - 4 glucose tablets
 - 1/2 cup fruit juice
 - 1 tablespoon honey
3. Wait 15 minutes and recheck
4. Repeat if still low
5. Eat a small snack once stable

Hyperglycemia (High Blood Sugar)

Symptoms

- Frequent urination
- Increased thirst
- Blurred vision
- Fatigue
- Headache

Management

- Drink water to stay hydrated
- Check for ketones if blood sugar is very high
- Take correction dose if prescribed
- Avoid exercise if blood sugar is above 250 mg/dL
- Contact doctor if persistently high

Living Well with Diabetes

Lifestyle Tips

- Carry diabetes ID at all times
- Keep emergency supplies accessible
- Plan ahead for meals and travel
- Build a support network
- Stay informed about diabetes management
- Attend diabetes education classes

Technology Tools

- Continuous glucose monitors (CGM)
- Insulin pumps
- Smartphone apps for tracking
- Telemedicine consultations
- Online support communities

When to Contact Your Healthcare Provider

- Blood sugar consistently outside target range
- Frequent episodes of hypoglycemia
- Signs of infection
- New or worsening symptoms
- Questions about medications
- Planning pregnancy
- Before starting new exercise program

Important Reminders

⚠ **Medical Disclaimer:** This guide is for educational purposes only and does not replace professional medical advice.
Always consult your healthcare provider for personalized diabetes management.

☐ **Emergency:** Call 911 or seek immediate medical attention for severe symptoms, loss of consciousness, or diabetic emergencies.

- **Medication:** Never adjust insulin or medication doses without consulting your doctor.

Last Updated: 2026 Source: General diabetes management guidelines